

We Will Never Know

Emmy Schulz

Dear Uncle Jay,

You have placed in my life the most real feeling of “we will never ever know.” You cut a new wound in my skin, deeper than any other. I have been through a lot in this life. I have learned to keep standing up, but this new weight has made it harder every morning to get back on my feet.

Love, E

I stare at my pile of picked-off red nail polish on the table. It was an attempt to delay these thoughts, but honestly, I think writing this essay might save me. The feeling of loss is not a new endeavor. I have dealt with it my entire life; it’s like I was born with it. I have grieved my father, who died from a heart attack when I was one year old, but he was taken from this world. My uncle Jay took himself from this world, creating a new type of loss. This one is filled with anger, confusion, and a little resentment. I am angry that my family and I have to go through this again, I am confused because there were no signs at all, and I am resentful because why would he do this knowing how much pain it would cause?

September is a month I will now dread, as now it will only remind me of the ring of my phone that night and the sobs that continuously followed. Since that night I have not slept, I go through my day and feel guilty when I am distracted enough to the point that I forget it all even happened, but when I lay down, I can only think of him. “We are all dying, but we are living. The key is to live with as much dignity as you can and never ever bring people down because you’ve given up on life” (Laymon, Online book Pg 177). I disagree with this statement, as I don’t think anyone should force themselves to hide that they’re hurting, just so that they don’t

bring others down. My uncle was a father to two young girls under the age of 16, and he was a father figure to my five siblings and me, he was my mom's only brother. Jason was an incredible person and witnessed hardship of his own, but it never stopped him from showing up for the people he loved most. But unlike this quote from the book, I wish he didn't have the dignity and strength to not show that he was struggling, I wish that he would have given any sign, that he was giving up on his life.

Dear Uncle Jay,

You watched my mom lose the love of her life; you experienced the pain that death causes. You held me as a baby while my mom buried my dad. You hated to see her suffer and yet you took your own life, inflicting lifelong torture on her and our entire family. You watched in agony as my siblings and I grew up without a father and yet, you just willingly did the same thing to your very own daughters. Leaving us all to dwell on the fact that we will never ever know. I wish I did not feel bitter, and I do not want to sound as if I am filled with hatred. But you lied last month when you told me you'd see me soon, and now I am forced to be okay with the fact that there is nothing that I could have done? "I never questioned your love for me or for the family. I knew you loved us" (Laymon, online book Pg 175). I never even questioned your mental well-being; you were too good at hiding your struggles. I never have and will never question how much you loved and cared for us, but I am stuck in a feeling of helplessness where I can't stop thinking that I could have done something more to prevent this.

I love you- I really, really do,

-E

In my dreams, Jason and I walk through the woods behind his house. But in the end, I turn around to find him gone. I sob and scream because I didn't get to tell him that I see him, I

understand him, I love him. I didn't get to tell him he doesn't need to suffer in silence. I feel nauseous when I think of living the rest of my life asking myself "Why?" My eyes get glossy when I imagine everything I would say to him right now. I try to avoid it, but I will never stop thinking about it.

Dear Uncle Jay,

I do not hate you, I never could and never will. I do not resent you, I am just hurting- our entire family is. You were a person who helped make my world keep spinning, you fought to keep me alive when I was drowning in my very own mind. I am giving everything in me to stop myself from feeling guilty that I was not given the opportunity to return that favor to you. "That's what I needed to tell you when you were alive, that's what I needed you to show me. That's what I need to keep believing." (Laymon, online book Pg 174).

Love, E

When reading "How to Slowly Kill Yourself and Others in America", I physically laughed aloud. How is it that something like this happens to me, and the next week we read a story so similar? Is it simply coincidence or does the world just enjoy setting everything up to connect? In this chapter of the book, we are taken through how Uncle Jimmy was giving up on his life, and his family felt and began to grieve his loss even before he was gone. They wrote him letters and talked about how Jimmy affected their lives. The quotes I pulled from this chapter were picked because I felt the emotion in them, the regret and grief. I related to them, and it was almost comforting. This assignment was comforting, even when it was uncomfortable to think about the loss. It helped me begin the long journey of processing what has happened to my family.

